

SILENT PROCESSING

SILENCE IS
NOT DISCONNECTION



POST-MATCH SILENCE IS A NERVOUS SYSTEM RESPONSE, NOT A RELATIONSHIP PROBLEM.



THE SERIES

FIVE LESSONS. ONE PLAYER.

01

Silence Is Not Disconnection

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02

What Not to Do in the Post-Match Window

Coming up.

03

Building Her Processing System

Coming up.

04

Your Body Language During the Match

Coming up.

05

The Conversation She Can Have

Coming up.

HEAR THIS ONCE

WHEN YOUR DAUGHTER SHUTS
DOWN AFTER A MATCH, SHE IS NOT
AVOIDING YOU. SHE IS STILL
PROCESSING, PHYSICALLY,
EMOTIONALLY, AND MENTALLY.

After competition, an athlete's brain and body are still in recovery mode. Even if the game looked fine from the stands, she may be processing mistakes, a look from the coach, teammates' reactions, and the voice in her head that says she wasn't good enough.

— SILENCE IS PROCESSING, NOT REJECTION · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE POST-MATCH WINDOW

AFTER THE MATCH, HER NERVOUS SYSTEM DOESN'T TRANSITION TO 'NORMAL' INSTANTLY. GIVE IT THE TIME IT NEEDS.

- Physical exhaustion: her body is still recovering from the demands of competition
- Emotional overload: the feelings from every play haven't settled yet
- Mental replay: she is still in the match, even if she's sitting in the car

— THE SILENCE AFTER THE MATCH IS NOT THE END OF THE CONVERSATION. IT IS A TRANSITION.

05 · THE BREAKDOWN

WHAT SHE'S CARRYING

HER OWN REPLAY

Mistakes she felt deeply. The look from the coach. The moment she thinks cost the team a point.

YOURS TOO

If you were visibly reactive during the match, she is also carrying your emotional reaction alongside her own.

THE INNER CRITIC

The voice saying 'I'm not good enough' or 'I let everyone down' is still running at full volume.



WHAT HELPS

IN PRACTICE

Say nothing on the way to the car. Let her make the first move.

WATCH FOR

The moment she's ready: it's usually 30-90 minutes after the match. Don't force it before then.

THE SHIFT

From trying to connect immediately to creating the space that makes connection possible.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

SHE IS NOT AVOIDING YOU. SHE IS
STILL IN THE GAME. GIVE HER THE
TIME TO WALK OUT OF IT.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

— THE WINDOW LAW

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, PRACTICE THE POST-MATCH SILENCE.

✓ After the next match, make a pact: no conversation initiated by you until she speaks first

✓ Offer presence without pressure: a hand on the shoulder, no words needed

✓ When she does speak, ask: 'What do you need right now?' Not: 'What happened?'

✓ Track the window: how long until she's ready? Watch it shrink over the season.

SILENT PROCESSING

WHAT NOT TO DO
IN THE POST-MATCH
WINDOW

02

THE CAR RIDE HOME IS EITHER THE MOST DAMAGING OR THE MOST HEALING PART OF THE DAY.

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HEAR THIS ONCE

MORE PARENT-ATHLETE
RELATIONSHIP DAMAGE HAPPENS IN
THE CAR RIDE HOME THAN IN THE
STANDS DURING THE MATCH.

The post-match car ride is high-stakes. Both parent and athlete are in emotionally activated states. Feedback, analysis, and play-by-play in this window doesn't land as coaching, it lands as one more load for her to carry.

— THE CAR RIDE IS A SACRED WINDOW · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE CAR RIDE STANDARD

WHAT YOU SAY IN THE CAR RIDE HOME WILL STAY IN HER HEAD LONGER THAN ANYTHING THAT HAPPENED ON THE COURT.

- What doesn't work: play-by-play analysis, asking what happened, offering unsolicited feedback
- What works: silence, 'I love watching you play,' presence without pressure
- The question that always works: 'What do you need from me right now?'

— THE CAR RIDE HOME IS NOT A DEBRIEF. IT IS A RECOVERY WINDOW.

05 · THE BREAKDOWN

THE CAR RIDE MISTAKES

ANALYSIS

'Here's what I noticed in the second set...' she doesn't have the capacity to receive this yet.

QUESTIONS

'Why did you do that in game three?' This reopens the wound before it has closed.

SILENCE AS PUNISHMENT

Going quiet because you're frustrated, she feels this as rejection or disappointment.



THE CAR RIDE PRACTICE

IN PRACTICE

Commit to one rule: nothing in the car unless she asks. 'I love watching you play' is always allowed.

WATCH FOR

Your own urge to process the match through her, name it, pause it, redirect it.

THE SHIFT

From the car as a debrief location to the car as a recovery space.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

WHAT YOU SAY IN THE CAR RIDE
HOME LIVES IN HER HEAD DURING
THE NEXT MATCH. CHOOSE IT
CAREFULLY.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

— THE RECOVERY LAW



THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, SET THE CAR RIDE STANDARD.

✓ Before the next match, decide what you will and won't say in the car ride home

✓ Commit to: 'I love watching you play' as your go-to phrase

✓ Add: 'What do you need from me right now?' if she seems upset

✓ After one week: ask her: 'How has the car ride been feeling lately?'

SILENT PROCESSING

BUILDING HER
PROCESSING SYSTEM

03

SHE DOESN'T HAVE TO TALK TO YOU. SHE DOES NEED A SYSTEM FOR PROCESSING.



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HEAR THIS ONCE

THE GOAL IS NOT FOR YOUR DAUGHTER TO DEBRIEF THE MATCH WITH YOU. THE GOAL IS FOR HER TO HAVE A SYSTEM FOR PROCESSING HER EXPERIENCE, WITH OR WITHOUT YOU.

Athletes who have no processing system carry unprocessed emotional load from match to match. This compounds into burnout, anxiety, and emotional dysregulation. The solution is not forced conversation — it's a system she owns.

— SHE NEEDS A SYSTEM, NOT JUST A LISTENER · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE PROCESSING SYSTEM

SHE DOESN'T NEED TO TALK TO YOU. SHE NEEDS A WAY TO PROCESS. HELP HER FIND WHAT WORKS FOR HER.

- Movement: walk, run, bike, physical activity as emotional processing
- Writing: a private journal or notes app where the match can be put down on paper
- Music: a specific playlist that marks the transition from match to everything else

— A SYSTEM SHE OWNS IS MORE POWERFUL THAN A CONVERSATION SHE FEELS FORCED INTO.

PROCESSING OPTIONS

PHYSICAL

Movement processes cortisol and adrenaline, a 20-minute walk after a hard match changes the nervous system state.

WRITTEN

A private post-match note: what happened, what I felt, what I'm leaving behind. No audience required.

CREATIVE

Music, art, or anything that creates a deliberate transition between the match and the rest of the day.



BUILDING THE SYSTEM

IN PRACTICE

Ask: 'What feels best after a hard match, moving, writing, music, or something else?'

WATCH FOR

Whether she has anything right now or whether she's been absorbing without processing.

THE SHIFT

From hoping she vents to you to building something sustainable that she can use independently.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

THE ATHLETE WITH A PROCESSING
SYSTEM IS CARRYING LESS
EMOTIONAL WEIGHT INTO EVERY
MATCH THAT FOLLOWS.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

08 · THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, BUILD ONE PROCESSING TOOL.

✓ Ask: 'What do you do right now after a hard match to transition out of it?'

✓ If the answer is 'nothing,' offer three options: move, write, or music

✓ Let her choose, and try it after the next match

✓ Check in one week later: 'Did it help? Is there something that works better?'



SILENT PROCESSING

YOUR BODY LANGUAGE
DURING THE MATCH



IF YOU WERE REACTIVE IN THE STANDS, SHE'S NOT JUST PROCESSING THE MATCH — SHE'S PROCESSING YOURS TOO.



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HEAR THIS ONCE

AFTER A HARD MATCH, YOUR
ATHLETE MAY BE CARRYING TWO
SETS OF EMOTIONS: HER OWN AND
THE ONES SHE READ FROM YOU IN
THE STANDS.

Parents who shake their heads, sigh audibly, or visibly react to mistakes are adding to the emotional load their athlete carries post-match. She reads you in real time, and that data has to be processed alongside everything else.

— YOUR MATCH-TIME BODY LANGUAGE IS HER POST-MATCH PROCESSING · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE SECOND LOAD

SHE IS NOT JUST PROCESSING
THE MATCH. SHE IS PROCESSING
WHAT YOU SHOWED HER FROM
THE STANDS.

- Head shakes, sighs, and visible frustration, read instantly and stored for post-match processing
- The athlete who carries her parent's emotion alongside her own has twice the work to do
- Neutral, present, consistent sideline energy is one of the most powerful performance gifts you can give

— YOUR MATCH-TIME BODY LANGUAGE IS PART OF HER POST-MATCH LOAD. MANAGE IT.

05 · THE BREAKDOWN

THE SIDELINE-TO-CAR PIPELINE

DURING THE MATCH

She found you in the crowd. She read your face. She stored it.

AFTER THE MATCH

That read, your emotion, is part of what she's processing in the silence.

THE COMPOUNDING EFFECT

A tense parent plus a hard match creates a heavier post-game processing load than either alone.



THE SIDELINE PRACTICE

IN PRACTICE

At the next match, commit to: neutral face, still body, consistent energy, regardless of the score.

WATCH FOR

Your own reactive moments, and what she does right after she looks up and sees them.

THE SHIFT

From processing the match yourself from the stands to holding steady so she can process hers from the court.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

THE STEADIER YOU ARE IN THE
STANDS, THE LESS SHE HAS TO CARRY
AFTER THE FINAL WHISTLE.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, AUDIT YOUR SIDELINE BODY LANGUAGE.

✓ At the next match, ask a trusted person to tell you honestly about your sideline body language

✓ Note: when did you visibly react? What triggered it?

✓ Commit to one change: still body during a specific type of moment (errors, bad calls)

✓ After the match, ask your daughter: 'How did my energy feel from the stands today?'



SILENT PROCESSING

THE CONVERSATION
SHE CAN HAVE

OS

NOT EVERY ATHLETE PROCESSES VERBALLY. AND THAT'S FINE — UNTIL IT BECOMES ISOLATION.



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HEAR THIS ONCE

THE GOAL IS NOT FOR YOUR DAUGHTER TO BE A VERBAL PROCESSOR. THE GOAL IS FOR HER TO HAVE ENOUGH SUPPORT THAT THE LOAD DOESN'T COMPOUND INTO SOMETHING SHE CARRIES ALONE AND CAN'T PUT DOWN.

Some athletes will never debrief the match with their parents. That's not a failure. The question to ask is: does she have someone, some system, some way of setting down what she carries? If yes, the silence is fine. If not, that's the real work.

— SUPPORTED SILENCE IS HEALTHY. ISOLATED SILENCE IS NOT. · MAZEPERFORMANCE

S U P P O R T E D S I L E N C E

SHE DOESN'T HAVE TO TALK TO YOU. SHE DOES NEED TO BE SUPPORTED — NOT ALONE IN WHAT SHE'S CARRYING.

- Supported silence: she has a system, a person, or a practice that processes the load, and you know it
- Isolated silence: she has nothing and no one, the load compounds, match after match
- Your job: ensure the support exists, even if it's not with you

— SILENCE PLUS SUPPORT IS HEALTH. SILENCE PLUS ISOLATION IS A WARNING SIGN.

THE SUPPORT CHECK

THE QUESTIONS

'Does she have a teammate she talks to? A journal? A physical outlet? Anything?'

THE SIGNAL

If she seems to carry match stress into the next day, next week, or next match: the system isn't working.

THE INTERVENTION

'I notice you seem like you're still in the last match. Is there something you're still carrying?'



BUILDING THE SUPPORT MAP

IN PRACTICE

Know what her processing system is and check in on it — not on the match. 'How's your system working?'

WATCH FOR

Persistent tension, irritability, or emotional spillover from volleyball into other areas of life.

THE SHIFT

From managing the silence to building the support system that makes it healthy.



SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

SILENCE WITH SUPPORT IS HEALTHY.
SILENCE WITHOUT SUPPORT IS A
LOAD THAT COMPOUNDS — UNTIL
SOMETHING BREAKS.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, CHECK THE SUPPORT MAP.

✓ Ask (not about the last match): 'Who do you usually talk to when volleyball feels heavy?'

✓ If the answer is no one, don't panic, ask: 'What helps you put it down?'

✓ Build or reinforce one support tool with her this week

✓ Let her know: 'You don't have to process with me. But I want to make sure you're not alone in it.'

